



Department Elevation Strategy

Program of Landscape Architecture → Department of Landscape Architecture

Date: June 29, 2026 | Prepared by: W. Chris Harrison, MLA, ASLA

1 Executive Summary

THE CASE IN ONE SENTENCE

The Program of Landscape Architecture at NC A&T has reached a scale, enrollment trajectory, and institutional significance that warrants elevation from a **program within NRED** to a **stand-alone Department of Landscape Architecture** within CAES.

NC A&T's LA program is the **only LAAB-accredited undergraduate landscape architecture program at an HBCU in the United States**. Despite this distinction, it operates as a sub-unit of the Department of Natural Resources & Environmental Design — sharing budget lines, faculty governance, and administrative infrastructure with forestry, geomatics, and environmental studies.

This structure creates friction: competing priorities for faculty lines, limited control over curriculum scheduling, diluted identity in recruitment, and an organizational mismatch with peer institutions where landscape architecture operates as an independent department or school.

Only

LAAB-ACCREDITED LA
PROGRAM AT AN HBCU

40

ADMITTED FRESHMEN
FALL 2026

6.0

INSTRUCTIONAL FTE
(EXCEEDS LAAB MIN. 5)

2 Current Structure vs. Proposed Structure

✗ Current: Program within NRED

Administrative Unit	Sub-program of Dept. of NRED
Leadership	Program Coordinator (no chair authority)
Budget	Shared NRED allocation — no dedicated LA budget line
Faculty Lines	Requested through NRED — competes with forestry, geomatics, env. studies
Curriculum Control	Changes require NRED dept. committee + Dept. Head approval
Recruitment Identity	Listed under "NRED" — diluted brand
Accreditation	LAAB evaluates LA but reports go through NRED infrastructure

✓ Proposed: Department of LA

Administrative Unit	Department of Landscape Architecture
Leadership	Department Chair — direct report to Dean
Budget	Dedicated departmental budget — independent allocation
Faculty Lines	Direct faculty requests — no competition with other programs
Curriculum Control	Own curriculum committee — faster, focused decisions
Recruitment Identity	"Dept. of Landscape Architecture" — clear, prestigious brand
Accreditation	Direct LAAB alignment — department-level self-study

3 Peer Institution Benchmarking

Nearly all LAAB-accredited landscape architecture programs operate as **departments** or **schools** — not sub-programs. NC A&T's current structure is an outlier among peers.

INSTITUTION	STRUCTURE	DEGREES	FACULTY	NOTES
Penn State	Dept. of Landscape Architecture	BLA, MLA	12+ FTE	Independent dept. within College of Arts & Architecture
Clemson University	Dept. of Landscape Architecture	BLA, MLA	10+ FTE	College of Architecture, Arts and Humanities
Ball State University	Dept. of Landscape Architecture	BLA, MLA	8+ FTE	College of Architecture and Planning
University of Georgia	School of Environmental Design	BLA, MLA	14+ FTE	Standalone school — highest level
Morgan State (HBCU)	Dept. within School of Arch. & Planning	MLA	6+ FTE	Graduate only — closest HBCU peer
NC A&T (Current)	Program within Dept. of NRED	BS only	6.0 FTE	⚠️ Only HBCU with LAAB-accredited BS — yet operates as sub-program

⚠️ STRUCTURAL DISADVANTAGE

NC A&T is the **only peer institution** where landscape architecture does not have departmental or school-level autonomy. This limits our ability to recruit, retain faculty, control curriculum, and compete for grants at the level our accreditation warrants.

4 Strategic Benefits of Elevation

Academic & Accreditation

- **LAAB alignment:** Department-level self-study strengthens accreditation narrative
- **Curriculum agility:** Own committee = faster response to industry changes
- **MLA pathway:** Department status is a prerequisite for proposing a graduate program
- **Faculty tenure:** LA-specific tenure criteria (Appendix G) governed by LA faculty
- **Studio ratio control:** Direct management of 15:1 LAAB requirement

Financial & Grants

- **Dedicated budget line:** No competition with forestry/geomatics for resources
- **Grant eligibility:** Many federal grants (USDA, NEA, EPA) require departmental-level applicants
- **Endowment potential:** Alumni/industry donations directed to named department
- **Scholarship growth:** Department-level fundraising vs. program-level requests

Recruitment & Visibility

- **Clear identity:** "Dept. of Landscape Architecture" vs. "NRED Program" on diplomas and transcripts
- **Website presence:** Own departmental landing page, not buried under NRED
- **ASLA/CLARB visibility:** Department status listed in national directories
- **Student recruitment:** Prospective students search for "departments" — programs are harder to find
- **HBCU distinction:** First HBCU with a *Department* of Landscape Architecture

Faculty & Governance

- **Chair position:** Direct report to Dean — voice at College leadership table
- **Hiring autonomy:** Faculty search committees controlled by LA faculty
- **Workload management:** Department-level decisions on teaching loads, releases, sabbaticals
- **Preeminence 2030:** Aligns with NC A&T's strategic goal of elevating R1-caliber programs

5 Requirements for Elevation

REQUIREMENT	NC A&T LA STATUS	ASSESSMENT
Minimum 5 FTE faculty	6.0 FTE (4 FT + adjuncts)	✓ Exceeds
Sustained enrollment growth	40 admitted Fall 2026 (record high)	✓ Strong trajectory
Accreditation in good standing	LAAB-accredited, next review cycle on track	✓ Active
Distinct curriculum (not shared)	100% LDAR-prefix courses; no shared courses with NRED	✓ Fully independent
Dedicated studio/lab space	CARVE 205, 213 (proposed), C.H. Moore (proposed)	⚠ Needs expansion
Dean support	To be confirmed	⚠ Discussion needed
Provost / Faculty Senate approval	Requires formal proposal	Pending
SACSCOC notification	Organizational change — may require substantive change report	Pending

✓ KEY FINDING

The LA program already meets the fundamental academic criteria for departmental status: sufficient FTE, independent curriculum, active accreditation, and growing enrollment. The remaining requirements are **administrative approvals**, not academic deficiencies.

6 Proposed Timeline — 3-Phase Approach

Phase 1
Fall 2026 – Spring 2027
Build the Case

Phase 2
Fall 2027 – Spring 2028
Formal Proposal

Phase 3
Fall 2028
Department Launch

Phase 1: Build the Case (Fall 2026 – Spring 2027)

- ☐ **P1** Document enrollment trends, FTE, and accreditation metrics **HARRISON**
- ☐ **P1** Benchmark peer LA departments (Penn State, Clemson, Ball State, UGA) **HARRISON**
- ☐ **P1** Draft preliminary budget model showing cost-neutrality **HARRISON / PERRY HOWARD**
- ☐ **P1** Secure informal Dean endorsement — lunch meeting **HARRISON / DR. ARYAL**
- ☐ **P1** Brief LAAB on planned organizational change (informational) **HARRISON**
- ☐ **P1** Align with Preeminence 2030 Blueprint — Goal 1 language **HARRISON**

Phase 2: Formal Proposal (Fall 2027 – Spring 2028)

- ☐ **P2** Submit formal proposal to CAES Dean with budget, staffing plan, and accreditation impact analysis **HARRISON / DR. ARYAL**
- ☐ **P2** Present to CAES Faculty Assembly for endorsement **HARRISON**
- ☐ **P2** Route through Provost's Office and Faculty Senate **DEAN'S OFFICE**
- ☐ **P2** Prepare SACSCOC substantive change notification (if required) **PROVOST'S OFFICE**
- ☐ **P2** Identify and hire Department Chair candidate (or appoint from within) **DEAN / SEARCH COMMITTEE**

Phase 3: Department Launch (Fall 2028)

- ☐ **P3** Official launch: Department of Landscape Architecture within CAES **CHANCELLOR'S OFFICE**
- ☐ **P3** Update Banner, website, and all university systems **IT / UNIVERSITY RELATIONS**
- ☐ **P3** New departmental budget code active **BUSINESS & FINANCE**
- ☐ **P3** Press release and recruitment campaign — "First HBCU Dept. of LA" **UNIVERSITY RELATIONS**
- ☐ **P3** Begin MLA graduate program feasibility study **NEW CHAIR**

7 Risks & Mitigation

RISK	LIKELIHOOD	IMPACT	MITIGATION
Dean declines — budget concerns	Medium	High	Present cost-neutral model. LA generates tuition from 18 out-of-state students × \$26K = \$468K revenue. Department doesn't add cost — it reorganizes existing resources.
NRED Dept. Head opposes — loses faculty lines	Medium	Medium	Frame as mutual benefit: NRED can refocus on forestry/geomatics growth without LA workload distortion. Offer transition support.
Faculty Senate delays — bureaucratic timeline	Low	Medium	Start early (Phase 1 now). Build coalition of supporting faculty before formal submission.
SACSCOC requires substantive change	Low	Low	Organizational restructuring without new degrees typically requires notification only, not full review.
Enrollment dip weakens case	Low	High	Convert 28 un-deposited admits NOW. Strong Fall 2026 cohort is the foundation of this entire strategy.

8 Cost-Neutrality Argument

💡 THE KEY MESSAGE

Elevation does not require new funding. It reorganizes **existing resources** (faculty, space, budget) under a more effective administrative structure. The department already generates significant tuition revenue.

Revenue Generated by LA Program

In-state students (22 × ~\$8K tuition)	~\$176,000
Out-of-state students (18 × ~\$26K tuition)	~\$468,000
Total annual tuition revenue	~\$644,000

Net Cost of Department

Faculty salaries (4 FT + 3 adjunct)	Already budgeted in NRED
Administrative support	Share with CAES (existing staff)
Space	CARVE 205 + 213 + C.H. Moore (existing)
Incremental cost	~\$0 (reorganization)